



Erin Chute
Commissioner

TOWN of BROOKLINE
Massachusetts
Department of Public Works

Amory Playground DRC Meeting #2
Wednesday, May 1st, 2024

Panelists: Alexandra Vecchio, Jessie Waisnor, Clara Batchelor, Antonia Bellalta, Lauren Bernard, Jane Flanagan, Wyatt Brooks, Philip Kramer, Fran Perler, Andrew Gutterman, Phyllis Zhou, Kira Sargent, Kongyun He, Trey Sasser, Zachary Chrisco, Mike Frechette, Austin Geary, Sam Downes

Attendees: John Schreffler, Nora Sanders, Katelyn Avruch, Stuart Rubinow, Isabel Zuckoff, Anna Tanasijevic, William Stone, Matthew Arnstein, Judith Havens, Debra Samdperil, Ross Yellin, Brad Lucas, Paul Ha, Russell Frye, John Bowman, Dave Walker, Eli Gurock, Beth Jones, Marjorie Whittaker, Eleanor Peters, Randy Parker, Jesse Hefter, Alan Grossman, Scott Enos, Marcia Goldberg, Dean Bogdanovic, Diane Souvaine, Alina Roytberg, John Eustace, Bob Schram, Greta Michalczuk, Blanka Bogdanovic, Raffi Der Sarkissian, Oliver Hughes, Tom Johnson, Diane Johnson, Michael Wojcik, Jerry Wolosenko, Mark Nemes, Elaine Ullian, Rob Schoen, Deborah Cohen, Paul Ridker, Alina Roytberg, Anthony Ishak, Russ Russell, Dudley Post, Jesse Dayy, Michael Caplan, Kathleen McKenna, Sheera Hefter, Allan Fujita

Welcome/Call Meeting to Order

A. Vecchio welcomed all to the meeting. Staff and Consultants from Sasaki introduced themselves.

Overview of Project and Scope of Work

P. Zhou went through and highlighted the priority areas of the project: the parking lot, the sanctuary's boardwalks, the hillside along Amory St, the field house and adjacent landscape, and the tennis courts. She then reviewed the project schedule noting that the next meeting is on June 24th as the meeting on May 29th was cancelled due to time conflicts with the Town Meeting. There will be a fourth design review meeting in July if necessary.

Presentation of Design Concepts (excluding Tennis Courts)

K. Sargent presented the feedback received for various park elements. She notes that the feedback indicates that people want more welcoming and safe entrances to the park, with additional bike parking at all entrances, as well as addressing the eroded edge of the parking lot and using the area to the north of the parking lot for stormwater management or educational elements. She then reviewed the feedback regarding pedestrian circulation noting that the key

takeaways were to improve the ADA access near the field house and that there was a desire to formalize the informal path along the top of the hillside. She noted that there was discussion about lighting but that is not in the scope of the project as the park is only open from dawn until dusk. She also mentions that people want to keep the paths pedestrian-oriented rather than encourage bike usage on the park pathways. She then reviewed the feedback on the park amenities noting that much of the feedback desired improvements to existing amenities rather than the addition of new amenities. She mentioned that there is a desire to add more benches and that they will be looking at the distribution of benches across the park. She notes that many dog owners use the park and that additional signage for proper usage of the park as well as more waste disposal bins was expressed. She also noted there was a desire to consider adding outdoor exercise equipment to the park. She then reviewed the feedback regarding the topography and slope of the park noting that stormwater management is key in this project. They are looking at adding some overviews or spots that highlight the views of the Boston skyline. She remarked that there is a strong desire to keep the hillside largely the same shape that is currently as people use it for passive recreation. She then reviewed the natural landscape and vegetation noting that there are currently three different areas of vegetation, the canopy trees and lawn along the hillside, the dense vegetation in Hall's Pond Sanctuary, and the willow mixed tree species separating the playground from the sanctuary. She notes that they will only remove the overhanging vegetation and invasive species from the parking lot fence as well as look at succession planting for the canopy trees which are near end-of-life along the hillside. She then reviewed the sanctuary paths and boardwalk. She notes that the feedback indicated that users wanted the current boardwalk layout kept the way it is and to maintain the rustic look and feel. She notes that the railings need to be replaced, specifically at the overlook and areas leading up to them. She also noted that there are sections that will need structural upgrades and that they will ensure ADA compliance on all paths, specifically noting that some slopes and grades will be smoothed out to ensure they are under the maximum tolerances.

A. Gutterman then walked through the guiding principles for their design concepts. The three principles are: to “Welcome and Connect” to improve entrances and circulation for all site users, to “Enhance Park Character” and emphasize different moments in the park and accentuate the natural landscape of the park, and to “Restore Site Features” to restore and renovate the existing amenities and features of the park.

A. Gutterman then went through the preliminary design Sasaki has come up with for various features. He began with the Amory Street Entrance noting that this is a fairly congested area and that their design attempts to discourage the informal parallel parking that is contributing to the degradation of the north side of the parking lot. They will be adding a bioswale to the north side of the parking lot to help with stormwater management and boulders to discourage vehicle parking at the edge of the pavement. He then notes that they will be separating the pedestrian path and the southern edge of the parking lot a bit more than what currently exists and add a line of trees between the walkway and the driveway. The first option keeps the same number of parking spaces that there are now and the second option replaces about 5 parking spaces with a rain garden to help with stormwater management.

A. Gutterman then went through the hillside area preliminary design. They are considering adding an overlook deck in the shaded area out of the way of any sledding paths and view sheds from above. They are looking at adding a pollinator garden in the open flat area on the hillside between the baseball fields. They are also looking at adding a new path at the top of the hill along Amory Street as there is no sidewalk there currently.

A. Gutterman then reviewed the design concept for the sanctuary entrance and the Beacon Street entrance. The design features additional seating and flowering trees along with additional bike parking at the Beacon Street entrance.

A. Gutterman then reviewed the boardwalk renovation. They will be replacing the decking of the boardwalk and making slight structural and bracing upgrades where needed. He mentioned that there are three options for the decking material. The three options are untreated wood, thermally modified wood, and plastic composite.

A. Gutterman then reviewed the design of the landscape around the field house. The design includes a new staircase and a new sloped ADA path in addition to additional signage and bike parking at the southwestern park entrance.

M. Frechette walked through the preliminary feedback and design concepts for the field house. The design features both restrooms being converted to single-user restrooms to comply with ADA accessibility guidelines, upgrading and replacing systems such as plumbing, lighting and ventilation, relocating the restroom doors, changing the overhead door to the Pro Shop to a person door as well as new wall cladding and daylighting. There are two design alternatives for the exterior improvements. Exterior option one features a new roof overhang over the doors to the restrooms and exterior option two features a metal mesh scrim on the left and right sides of the building from the foundation wings to the roof overhang. He mentioned that the material choice is focused on the priorities of efficiency, durability, and ease of maintenance.

Community Discussion and Feedback #1

C. Batchelor mentioned that the Beacon Street entrance to the park runs through a private parking lot and is uninviting and wants to see a more welcoming entrance. She brought up concerns about additional signage and trees as it would impact visibility at the parking lot and Amory Street intersection area where it is already an issue. She asked whether the guardrail between the perpendicular parking and the park would be kept. A. Gutterman replied that that they could add a curb to the south side of the parking lot but that adding a curb to the north side would effectively channel water runoff which would trigger different requirements. C. Batchelor brought up that the path at the bottom of the hillside causes issues as it would cause issues with the sledding during the winter and that the path parallel to Amory Street is a more appealing option.

A. Ishak expressed support for increasing bike parking and reducing car parking. He brings up concerns about keeping cars out of the proposed bioswale and rain garden areas and wants to see those areas protected from vehicles. He expressed support for the two wood options for the boardwalk decking over the plastic composite option. He proposed a public art area to help discourage graffiti.

A. Bellalta expressed concerns over the width of the parking lot and making sure that people do not back into the bioswale when reversing out of or into parking spots. She noted that modifying the height of the boardwalk will also necessitate more railings as more areas would have floors over thirty inches from the ground. A. Bellalta also expressed concern over a water drainage pipe near the field house. A. Gutterman replied that it looks like an interim drainage solution that they would be looking at fixing with the field house landscape. She expressed support for the second parking lot option with the rain garden and was concerned about cars driving over it. She also

derided the black netting on the tennis court fences and wished that it could be visually softened with trees.

W. Brooks expressed support for the trees along the tennis courts that A. Bellalta brought up. He was also supportive of the new ADA ramp by the field house. He expressed support for the path parallel to Amory Street at the top of the hill and suggested that it be a wider dust path so pedestrians do not interfere with sledding and so that the path is wide. He supported the rain garden option for the parking lot and echoed support for boulders to prevent parallel parking and to prevent trespassing into the rain garden.

P. Kramer expressed support for the rain garden, bioswale, and pollinator garden. He echoed C. Batchelor's comments about the Beacon Street entrance being unfriendly and uninviting. He opposed the plastic composite option for the boardwalk decking as it is uncomfortable and does not fit the feel of the sanctuary area. He was supportive of the outdoor exercise equipment but disagreed with the proposed placement of it as the area can be congested as it is. He opposed the conversion of the Pro Shop door to a person door as the current overhead door gives the staff a wide view that would be cut off with a person door. He also expressed concern over the ventilation of the Pro Shop with a person door rather than an overhead or folding door. He was concerned about adding too much additional visual cover to the tennis courts as it would impact the views of the park from the housing along Beacon Street. He supported the move of the restroom doors and the addition of the overhang but was concerned about having an obscured area where illicit activities might occur.

F. Perler also opposed the conversion of the Pro Shop door to a person door citing the lack of ventilation in the room. She expressed support for keeping as many parking spaces as possible as many of the park's attendees are people with mobility issues who may need to take a vehicle to the park. She noted that the design of the parking lot has to consider the entrance to Amory Woods and how that is designed as the current entrance is a chain-link fence with a butterfly gate latch that is hard to operate. She supported the options for the boardwalk which had a longer lifespan such as the plastic composite as she sees other wildlife sanctuaries moving to similar materials. She noted that some areas of the boardwalk should be raised as the water table in the area is very high and some sections are prone to flooding. She expressed that she wishes to see the fence separating Hall's Pond and the boardwalk lined with a pollinator garden.

J. Flanagan expressed concern for the amount of parking and how limiting the available parking would negatively affect those with mobility issues. She expressed support for making the Beacon Street entrance more inviting. She also expressed support for the path parallel to Amory Street along the top of the hill. She wished to see additional signage in the park focused on wayfinding and making sure people can find the amenities in the park. She opposed the plastic composite option for the boardwalk decking.

L. Bernard expressed support for increasing signage to make the Beacon Street entrance more inviting. She reiterated support for more wayfinding signage in the park. She is concerned about limiting parking as it would negatively impact those with disabilities.

C. Batchelor expressed concern over the roof overhang option for the field house as she thinks that it would draw too much visual attention compared to how the current field house fits into the landscape. She emphasized the role in the stairs from the southwestern entrance to the park down to the field house as being very important for circulation in the park.

J. Schreffler emphasized the need for a durable material for the boardwalk decking. He expressed desire to see the thermally treated wood option for the decking material. He wished to see the boardwalk raised in various places as parts can become flooded after heavy rains. He expressed concern over getting rid of parking due to how it would negatively impact elderly visitors.

R. Der Sarkissian expressed desire to see some lighting fixture to discourage illicit activities in the park.

Presentation of Design Concepts (Tennis Courts)

T. Sasser reviewed the feedback received for the surface material of the tennis courts. He mentioned that the wind screen and transparency issues will be dealt with during the actual court design time. He noted that there was support for higher nets to deal with stray baseballs and recycling locations around the courts. He remarked that the Amory Park tennis courts are the only Clay Courts in Brookline, the other 22 are all Hard Courts. They had received over 120 emails regarding the courts and 119 responses were in favor of keeping the courts clay. They had also received a petition from the Brookline Pickleball Community with 42 signatures in support of converting the courts to hard courts. He notes that there are three options for the tennis court materials: Har Tru/Fast Dry (soft court, the material the courts are currently composed of), Asphalt (hard court), and concrete (hard court).

Community Discussion and Feedback #2

P. Kramer expressed support for the clay courts mentioning the income from the vendor who runs the tennis program at the courts and that asphalt courts while having low maintenance costs require more complete restorations when they do become damaged or cracked.

T. Sasser asked J. Waisnor about the income received by the Town from the tennis program vendor. J. Waisnor clarified that the vendor pays the Town's Recreation department \$115,000 annually for the use of the tennis courts at both Amory Playground and Waldstein Playground.

C. Batchelor suggested that the contract with the tennis program vendor be renegotiated to have the courts be self-sustaining in terms of maintenance. She expressed support for the clay courts.

A. Bellalta also expressed support for the clay courts.

A. Vecchio explained that one of the issues with maintaining the clay courts is that finding a vendor to do the start-up and maintenance of the courts is becoming increasingly harder as there are fewer vendors in the area.

G. Michalczuk from 1440 Beacon Street expressed support for the clay courts.

D. Bogdanovic mentioned that newer technologies can reduce maintenance costs for clay courts.

P. Ridker from 1264 Beacon Street expressed support for the clay courts.

T. Johnson from 131 Freeman Street expressed support for the clay courts and suggested having the tennis program vendor be responsible for the start-up and maintenance of the courts as the clay court vendors may be more receptive to working with a private company as opposed to a municipality.

J. Hefter from 653 Chestnut Hill Avenue expressed support for the clay courts.

A. Fujita from 1056 Beacon Street expressed support for the clay courts.

Next Steps and Upcoming Meeting Dates

A. Gutterman stated that they will be taking this feedback and further refining designs and concepts for different areas of the park. The next meeting will be on June 24th, 2024.

Adjournment

The meeting was adjourned.